

FRAMING GENDER EQUALITY: LOCALIZING INTERNATIONAL GENDER NORMS IN CHINESE AND INDIAN OFFICIAL DISCOURSE

Yifei Jiang

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AI (Use) Statement

In writing this thesis, I used AI tools in a limited and specific way: to improve sentence structure and readability, and to clarify concepts and terminology in sources I found difficult to follow. This was particularly helpful given the cross-national and cross-linguistic nature of the analysis, which spans gender-related concepts, international treaty frameworks, and context-specific political terminology across two languages, including a small number of Hindi terms embedded in the Indian corpus.

All sources and factual claims were independently verified.

AI was not used to generate analysis, or arguments; all substantive work is my own.

Abstract

As China and India grow in geopolitical weight and multilateral influence, understanding how they construct the meaning of gender equality at home has become increasingly consequential for the future of international gender norms. This thesis examines how global gender norms are discursively localized through official framings of gender equality in Chinese and Indian state discourse between 2015 and 2025. Drawing on norm localization theory, political framing theory, and a typology of five domestic frames, it asks how two major rising powers engage with global gender equality commitments in domestic official discourse, which normative dimensions are emphasized or sidestepped, and what this reveals about the selective localization of international gender norms.

The empirical analysis draws on a close reading of 34 official texts and state-affiliated media documents. Three main findings emerge. First, developmental and instrumental framing dominates in both cases, though organized through distinct political logics: India's framing is more pluralistic and constitutionally anchored, while China's is more uniformly bounded by Party authority and socialist ideology. Second, both corpora share a consistent profile of omission: reproductive autonomy, SOGI-based rights, feminist civil society, and structural critiques of patriarchal power are systematically absent. Third, both states position themselves as significant normative contributors in global gender governance, yet their predominantly developmental and statist framing risks gradually narrowing the space for more liberal, individual autonomous rights-based interpretations internationally.

Keywords: gender equality, norm localization, political framing, rising powers, China, India, official discourse, global gender norms

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1. Introduction

Over the past several decades, international gender norms have become increasingly embedded in global governance. Principles such as gender equality, non-discrimination, and women's empowerment are institutionalized through major United Nations frameworks including CEDAW and the Beijing Platform for Action. At the same time, these norms reach into politically sensitive areas including family relations, reproduction, sexuality, and cultural values. Recent debates surrounding abortion rights, LGBTQ+ issues, and "gender ideology" further demonstrate that gender norms remain contested across different contexts. These tensions are sharpening alongside broader shifts in the international order. Global gender norms were promoted and institutionalised, from the 1970s onward (Chen, 1995), and as such are deeply rooted in the post-war liberal order. Yet as BRICS countries and other rising powers grow in institutional influence and increasingly contest the most liberal content of that order (Stephen, 2014), a pressing question emerges: what happens to international gender norms when the states that increasingly shape their meaning are no longer primarily liberal democracies? Some scholars warn that rising powers may erode progressive gender norms (Jacob et al., 2017); others point to more complex patterns of selective adaptation and localization (Vasudevan, 2019; Liu et al., 2024).

Existing scholarship has produced important insights into how rising powers engage with, adapt, or resist international gender norms at the institutional and legal levels. However, this literature has paid less attention to how international gender norms are officially framed and localized within domestic gender discourse, which dimensions of international gender norms they invoke or sidestep, how this process plays out in domestic gender discourse. This gap is consequential, since how rising powers construct the meaning of gender equality at home may increasingly shape what international gender norms can demand globally. This thesis therefore examines how China and India, two major rising powers both formally committed to international gender frameworks, narrate global gender norms for domestic audiences between 2015 and 2025. Drawing on norm localization theory (Acharya, 2004), political

framing theory (Entman, 1993), and a typology of five domestic framing patterns, it asks: how do China and India localize global gender norms through domestic official framings of gender equality, which dimensions are emphasized or left unaddressed, and what do these framing choices reveal about domestic political priorities and the possible future trajectory of international gender norms? In doing so, the thesis shifts analytical attention from institutional compliance to domestic political framing and extends existing debates beyond the European and North American contexts that dominate the current literature.

The thesis is organized as follows. Chapter 2 reviews the literature on global gender norms, rising powers, and existing research on China's and India's engagement with international gender norms. Chapter 3 develops the theoretical framework, drawing on insights from norm localization, political framing, and the discursive politics of gender norms. Chapter 4 outlines the interpretive qualitative research design and methodological approach, combining framing analysis with Bacchi's WPR approach to examine official discourse on gender in China and India. Chapter 5 presents the empirical analysis, examining how Chinese and Indian official discourse frames gender equality and engages with the more specific dimensions of global gender norms between 2015 and 2025. The final chapter summarizes the findings and reflects on the study's contributions and limitations.

2. Literature Review: Rising Powers and Global Gender Norms

This chapter reviews three bodies of scholarship that together provide the theoretical and empirical grounding for this study: the literature on international gender norms and their Western-centered institutionalization; scholarship on how rising powers adapt and contest international norms; and case-specific research on China's and India's engagement with global gender norms. The review shows that while existing scholarship has productively examined norm diffusion and resistance at the institutional and legal levels, it has paid less attention to how official domestic

discourse specifically constructs the political meaning of international gender norms – the dimension this thesis addresses.

2.1 Global gender norms: evolution and contestation

2.1.1 Global gender norms and the liberal order

A longstanding concern in international relations scholarship is how normative ideas take shape and become embedded in institutional practices. Gender norms provide a particularly clear illustration of this process. Over the past decades, international gender norms have become deeply integral to global governance arrangements, especially through transnational networks and the institutional framework of the United Nations (True & Mintrom, 2001). Research on global gender governance shows how gender norms such as gender mainstreaming and gender-balanced decision-making were gradually developed into global policy standards following key moments such as the 1995 Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, with CEDAW serving as the core treaty framework defining states' obligations in this area (Krook & True, 2010). More recently, scholars also note an expansion of these norms toward broader agendas of non-discrimination, including sexual orientation and gender identity, even though these remain more contested across states (Baisley, 2016).

Within this process, women's movements have been central to the emergence and promotion of global gender norms. Historical studies of international gender movements show that women's organizations and NGOs played a key role in placing women's rights on UN world conferences and international agendas (Chen, 1995, pp. 477–478), building cross-regional networks that sustained subsequent global policy processes (True & Mintrom, 2001). These mobilizations involved activists across local, national, and international levels, with consistent participation from the Global South – including a growing presence of new players and types of women's groups in developing countries (Chen, 1995, p. 480).

Yet this global participation in norm-building has not been equally reflected in how these norms have been studied or institutionally advanced. Bibliometric research on gender mainstreaming shows that scholarship on international gender norms has been dominated by scholars and institutions based in the Global North (Kataeva et al., 2024, p.2), who not only lead in research output but influence both the conceptual vocabulary and the policy agendas associated with global gender governance. At the same time, critical work on international gender norms suggest that such norms have long been embedded in hierarchical representations of liberal modernity and international order, in which Western states position themselves as normative leaders (Towns 2009 and 2010; Thomson, 2022). Taken together, this suggests that while global gender norms were originally advanced and shaped alongside transnational social movements by women from many different parts of the world, the academic study of these norms has focused disproportionately on Western actors.

2.1.2 Discursive contestation within Europe to global gender norms

The consolidation of international gender norms has not proceeded without resistance, including within Europe. A growing literature documents the rise of “anti-gender” movements, particularly from the 2010s onward,^[1] which oppose gender as a social construct, framing reproductive rights, LGBTQ+ rights, and other liberal-oriented gender norms as “gender ideology” externally imposed on traditional values and national sovereignty (Paternotte, 2018; Kuhar & Paternotte, 2017). These campaigns have emerged across a wide range of countries, mobilizing religious and conservative actors in transnational networks (Paternotte, 2018).

Graff and Korolczuk (2022) further argue that anti-gender politics has become closely intertwined with right-wing populism, where opposition to “gender” functions as a broader critique of liberal democracy and “cosmopolitan elites.” A particularly visible case of this contestation is the Istanbul Convention.^[2] Critics have framed it as

^[1] These campaigns originated in the mid-1990s as a Catholic reaction to the UN conferences of Cairo and Beijing, but developed significantly across Europe in the 2010s after crucial encounters with right-wing populism (Paternotte, 2018, p. 7).

^[2] The Istanbul Convention (Council of Europe, 2011) is a Council of Europe treaty on preventing and combating violence against women.

promoting "gender ideology," threatening traditional family structures, and infringing religious and national sovereignty (Krizsán et al., 2025). Such disputes over the Convention have driven non-ratification, withdrawal (Turkey, 2021), and open governmental challenges across several countries in Europe.^[3]

Against this backdrop, scholarly interest has grown in how anti-gender discourses are constructed, mobilized, and legitimized in political communication – with studies examining transnational conservative networks, framing strategies, and the relationship between gender politics and right-wing populism and illiberalism, primarily in European and Russian contexts (Graff & Korolczuk, 2022; Edenborg, 2023; Kuteleva, 2024). Far less attention, however, has been paid to how international gender norms are politically negotiated in non-Western rising powers, including where these norms become politically contested or encounter resistance within domestic discourse.

2.2 Rising Powers and International Norms

A growing body of international relations scholarship examines how rising powers interact with existing international norms. One prominent view holds that the rise of new powers may weaken or undermine liberal norms (Stephen, 2014; Cooley & Nexon, 2020). In the field of gender politics, Jacob et al. (2017) argue that the increasing influence of countries such as China, Russia, and India may erode the global norm of gender-balanced decision-making. They show that other states, especially those that are economically dependent on rising powers, may adjust their behaviour in line with the preferences of these emerging actors rather than those of established liberal norm leaders. From this perspective, shifts in material power can have direct consequences for the diffusion and strength of international gender norms.

^[3] Countries that have signed but not ratified the Istanbul Convention include Bulgaria, Czechia, Hungary, Latvia, Lithuania, and Slovakia. Turkey was the first country to withdraw, in 2021. Poland considered withdrawal under its previous government.

At the same time, other scholars present a more nuanced picture. Instead of simply rejecting or undermining them, rising powers are often seen as selective adopters that reinterpret and adapt global norms to fit domestic political priorities. Acharya (2004) describes this process as “norm localization,” arguing that international norms are reconstructed through local beliefs and institutional contexts. Later empirical studies similarly suggest that rising powers frequently combine formal acceptance of international commitments with selective implementation. In the area of gender and human rights, for example, research on India and China shows patterns of pragmatic engagement, adaptation, and strategic decoupling between international norms and domestic practice (Vasudevan, 2019; Liu, Xian, & Li, 2024).

Alongside these more ambivalent patterns, some cases show a more confrontational approach. Russia under Putin stands as a notable example of explicit rejection of liberal international gender and sexuality norms. A growing literature shows how the Russian state has actively promoted “traditional values” and framed gender norms and LGBTQ⁺ rights as foreign impositions and threats to national sovereignty and civilization, both domestically and in international forums (Edenborg, 2023; Moss, 2017). In this context, Russia has positioned itself as what Kuteleva (2024, p. 150) calls a “norm antipreneur,” resisting both the domestication and internationalization of pro-gender equality norms and feminist ideas.

Taken together, this literature provides valuable insights into whether and how rising powers challenge, reshape, adapt, or resist international norms. However, it remains largely focused on international-level outcomes, such as treaty ratification, institutional change, or voting behavior. Even in the Russian case, where discourse is central, the main concern is international ideological positioning and geopolitical contestation. Comparatively less attention has been paid to how international norms are systematically narrated and made meaningful within domestic political contexts, especially in more ambiguous cases such as China and India, where engagement with gender norms is neither openly confrontational nor fully compliant. I will turn to the literature on China’s and India’s engagement with global gender norms next.

2.2.1 China and global gender norms

A substantial body of scholarship examines China's engagement with international gender norms, especially through the lens of CEDAW and broader human rights governance. Early legal and policy analyses noted that China's ratification of CEDAW signaled an important symbolic commitment to international gender norms, while also emphasizing the gap between formal commitments and domestic implementation (McKenzie, 1991). More recent empirical studies confirm this pattern: although China shows relatively higher levels of formal adherence to gender equality norms compared to some other human rights areas, this adherence remains highly uneven and selective, reflecting the regime's prioritization of development, stability, and sovereignty over the indivisibility of rights (Song & Yang, 2023).

Building on this, an important strand of the literature conceptualizes China's approach as a form of pragmatic engagement with international human rights law. Liu, Xian, and Li (2024) argue that China has adopted a "pragmatic approach" characterized by selective appropriation of international norms, partial decoupling between international commitments and domestic rules, and divergent enforcement across issue areas, with women's rights under CEDAW displaying legislative progress but weak and uneven implementation in practice. From this perspective, CEDAW functions less as a transformative constraint and more as a flexible resource that can be used to improve international image while maintaining tight political control over feminist activism and social mobilization.

Beyond these institutional patterns, some scholars examine more directly how the Chinese state manages gender norms at the level of discourse and ideology. Drawing on content and critical thematic analysis of People's Daily (the CCP's flagship newspaper) from 2012 to 2024, Chen and Lu (2025) show that "gender equality" has emerged as the dominant framing of women's rights in the Xi era, conceptualizing this as "discursive state feminism," in which gender equality serves to reinforce political legitimacy and manage public expectations, while independent feminist voices are

marginalized as Western or politically suspect. While their work offers a valuable lens for understanding the discursive dimensions of China's gender governance, it focuses specifically on four terms^[4] within a single outlet and does not address how global gender norms are reframed and engaged with across domestic official discourse more broadly.

This discursive reframing is accompanied by more subtly controlled forms of institutional adaptation. Jiang and Zhou (2024), in their study of gender quota adoption, show that international norms were layered onto China's socialist legacy of gender equality and party control, producing institutional change that is real but politically bounded and carefully managed. At the international level, studies of China's role in multilateral human rights institutions similarly argue that Beijing increasingly seeks not only to comply selectively, but also to reshape the scope and meaning of human rights norms from within international forums, emphasizing development and sovereignty while downplaying more politically sensitive rights claims (Dukalskis, 2023).

These studies together show that China's engagement with international gender norms is a form of pragmatic and politically managed adaptation. Existing scholarship offers important insights into China's institutional adaptation, governance strategies, international positioning, and, to a lesser extent, thematic analyses of gender norms.

2.2.2 India and global gender norms

The literature on India's engagement with international gender norms depicts a pattern of formal commitment combined with selective adaptation and persistent contestation, especially in areas touching on family law, religion, and sovereignty. India ratified CEDAW in 1993, but did so with declarations and reservations, particularly concerning Articles 5(a) and 16 (which address the elimination of

^[4] The four terms are 女权主义 [feminism], 女性主义 [feminine-ism], 妇女解放 [women's liberation], and 性别平等 [gender equality] (Chen & Lu, 2025, p. 8).

discriminatory social and cultural practices and equality in marriage and family relations, respectively).^[5] Legal scholarship points to these declarations as revealing the inherent tension between India's international gender commitments and its accommodation of religious personal laws^[6] within a pluralist domestic legal framework (Holmes, 2019). In its declarations, the government indicated that these provisions would be implemented only in line with its policy of non-interference in community personal affairs without their initiative and consent, reflecting a broader political sensitivity of state intervention in religious and family matters.

Several studies analyze how CEDAW has functioned as both a legal and political resource in India, while remaining constrained by domestic social and institutional dynamics. Holmes (2019) argues that although Indian courts and lawmakers have at times invoked CEDAW to legitimize reforms in family and personal law, implementation remains uneven and deeply shaped by community politics and institutional resistance. Complementing this from a political incentive perspective, Vasudevan (2019) contends that India's engagement with CEDAW is further mediated by electoral incentives and conservative social preferences, producing uneven and often inconsistent patterns of compliance across different areas of gender policy.

Alongside these institutional accounts, a smaller body of scholarship examines how international gender norms are ideologically reframed within Indian political discourse. Drawing on the aftermath of the 2012 Delhi gang rape case, Kapur (2013, pp. 4-5) argues that responses to sexual violence in India increasingly relied on a state-centered discourse of security, protection, and criminal justice, positioning the state as the central guarantor of women's safety. Yet rather than fundamentally advancing gender equality, these responses reinforced what she terms a "sexual security regime," characterized by intensified surveillance, carceral governance, and

[5] India issued declarations on Articles 5(a) and 16 and a full reservation on Article 29. United Nations Treaty Collection, Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women, Declarations and Reservations: India, https://treaties.un.org/Pages/ViewDetails.aspx?src=TREATY&mtdsg_no=IV-8&chapter=4&clang=_en

[6] Religious personal laws in India govern matters such as marriage, divorce, inheritance, and custody for different religious communities. Rooted in British colonial codification rather than purely religious tradition, these laws have historically operated alongside the secular legal framework, creating significant variation in women's rights across communities (Parashar, 1992; Holmes, 2019).

the disciplining of gender and sexuality (p. 16). In this framework, the language of women's rights and protection ultimately becomes intertwined with sovereign authority and even stricter forms of gender regulation.

If domestic legal and ideological contestation shapes how India engages with gender norms internally, a comparable dynamic is evident in its conduct within multilateral institutions. Nanda (2019) shows that India has accepted many gender-related recommendations in the Universal Periodic Review process while "noting" or deflecting others, especially those concerning sexuality, marital rape, and personal laws. Klossek and Johansson-Nogués (2021) further demonstrate how India promotes itself internationally as a supporter of gender mainstreaming in UN peacekeeping, yet localizes this norm in highly restrictive ways within its own security sector. Overall, these studies point to India's engagement with international gender norms as shaped (or constrained) by religious personal law, the reassertion of state authority, and electoral pressures. While some scholarship has begun to touch on discursive dimensions, these accounts remain fragmented across policy domains and episodes.

To sum up the discussion above, existing scholarship provides rich insights into how international gender norms are institutionalized, how rising powers engage with them, and how China and India selectively adapt them through law and institutions. We now know a good deal about patterns of selective adoption, decoupling, and the domestic factors that drive resistance. However, this literature remains largely focused on institutional outcomes, while paying much less attention to how gender equality and its specific international normative commitments are officially framed and addressed in domestic discourse. This gap matters, since the domestic impact of global gender norms is not simply a product of institutional adoption, but of discursive processes through which states construct what these norms mean, what rights people can demand, where their boundaries lie. This thesis addresses this gap by shifting the analytical focus from norm adoption to political framing. While some studies on China and India have shed light on the discursive dimensions of gender norm engagement, they remain limited in scope and empirical coverage, do not yet provide a systematic picture of how global gender commitments (norms) are framed or

localized within domestic official discourse. Addressing this requires both a more coherent theoretical framework and broader empirical grounding.

3. Theoretical Framework: Norm Localization and Domestic Framing

This chapter develops the theoretical approach used to analyze how gender equality is framed in domestic official discourse and how global gender norms are localized through this process. The thesis adopts an interpretive, concept-driven framework grounded in a constructivist understanding of gender norms, and it combines insights from norm diffusion and localization (e.g., Acharya, 2004), political framing (e.g., Entman 1993) and literature on the discursive politics of gender equality, from which a typology of five domestic framing patterns is derived. The discussion concludes by presenting an analytical framework for the empirical analysis.

3.1 Global gender norms: a constructivist and hierarchical perspective

This section first clarifies what is meant by “global gender norms” in this study. Here, global gender norms are understood as internationally promoted principles and standards that define appropriate state behaviour in relation to gender relations, equality, and inclusion. In previous IR scholarship, international norms are generally treated not as fixed legal rules but as socially constructed standards of appropriate behaviour for states (Finnemore & Sikkink, 1998). Gender norms form a distinctive subset of such norms.

Substantively, contemporary international gender norms are anchored in several core principles, institutionalised both through global and regional multilateral frameworks. These include commitments to gender equality, understood as equal rights and opportunities for women and men; non-discrimination; elimination of gender-based violence; women's political participation, and gender mainstreaming, defined as the comprehensive integration of gender perspectives across policy domains (Krook & True, 2010; UN, 1995). In addition, although more contested, norms related to sexual

orientation and gender identity have increasingly become part of broader non-discrimination agendas (Baisley, 2016).

Critical feminist scholarship has shown that global gender norms operate not only as regulatory standards of appropriate conduct, but also as mechanisms of social ranking in international society (Towns, 2010 and 2012). In defining what counts as normal or desirable, as well as what is regarded as backwards or strange, norms enable comparative judgements and position states along hierarchies such as those between “modern” and “traditional” states. This “stratifying effect” of norms is closely tied to broader structures of global hierarchy, in which the diffusion and adoption of gender norms both draw on and contribute to the symbolic ordering of states and other actors in international society (Towns, 2012; Zarakol, 2017). This study therefore treats global gender norms both as a set of widely endorsed gender governing principles and as politically contested and hierarchically embedded signifiers.

3.2 Norm diffusion and localization

Building on this understanding of global gender norms, the following section examines how such norms enter domestic political arenas and why they are inevitably reinterpreted in domestic contexts.

International norms are not fixed or self-executing rules. A large body of scholarship shows that the influence of international norms is mediated through domestic political processes and the actions of domestic actors (Checkel, 1997; Cortell & Davis, 1996; Gurowitz 1999). From this perspective, international norms acquire domestic relevance only when they are taken up, interpreted, and contested within national political contexts. Cortell and Davis (1996) argue that global norms function as political resources that domestic actors may invoke selectively in policy debates. Depending on context, these norms may operate as genuinely constraining standards when they are deeply legalized, institutionalized, and widely recognized as authoritative. More often, however, they serve as rhetorical resources that actors

deploy to legitimize preferred policies, challenge opponents, or signal international credibility (pp. 452-453). Whether and how norms shape domestic outcomes thus depends on their domestic salience and on the structure of domestic political institutions. The former refers to the extent to which an international norm is seen as legitimate within domestic political debates, while the latter concerns the organization of decision-making authority and state-society relations that determine access to political processes (Cortell & Davis, 1996, pp. 454-456).

This emphasis on domestic agency is further developed by Gurowitz (1999), who shows that global norms become effective when mobilized by domestic actors such as civil society activists, lawyers, NGOs, and sympathetic state officials. Rather than constraining states directly, norms provide legitimating language and symbolic authority that domestic actors deploy strategically in courts, policy debates, and public discourse.

Acharya (2004) conceptualizes norm diffusion as a process of localization, through which local actors actively reconstruct external norms to ensure “congruence” with their cognitive priors, identities, and pre-existing normative orders (p. 243-244). Diffusion, in this view, is a selective and path-dependent process shaped by local normative structure. A central feature of localization is the agency of domestic actors. He emphasizes the role of “insider proponents,”— a group of credible local actors with sufficient discursive influence to act as translators between global and local normative frameworks (p. 248). Through mechanisms of framing, “pruning,” and “grafting”(p. 254), these actors link external norms to existing local ones, selecting elements that fit the existing normative structure and discarding those that do not.

Overall, this literature suggests that norm diffusion is inherently interpretive. As global norms enter domestic political arenas, they are inevitably translated and rearticulated through local normative orders and political struggles, which helps explain why international norms rarely produce uniform convergence, particularly in

non-Western contexts. These processes unfold primarily at the level of political discourse, where framing plays a crucial role.

3.3 Political framing as a mediating mechanism

To analyze how this discursive reconstruction takes place in practice, this study adopts political framing as a mediating analytical mechanism. Following Entman (1993), framing is understood as the process through which actors select certain aspects of a perceived reality and make them more salient in communication, thereby promoting a particular interpretation of an issue (p. 52). By highlighting some elements of reality while omitting others, frames structure how issues are understood and influence which interpretations appear meaningful or legitimate within public discourse (Entman, 1993, pp. 53-54).

Entman (1993) further specifies that frames perform four core functions: problem definition, causal diagnosis, moral evaluation, and treatment recommendation (p. 52). In this sense, frames define what the problem is, identify the forces that create the problem, make moral judgments about the causal agents and their effects, and suggest or justify possible remedies. Together, these provide a systematic template for analyzing different elements in how global norms are translated (i.e., framed) into domestic narratives and gain political relevance. Importantly, a frame does not necessarily contain all four elements explicitly; rather, frames are often constituted through partial and implicit combinations of these dimensions (Entman, 1993, p. 52). This makes the framework well suited for analyzing official political discourse on international gender norms, where meanings are often conveyed indirectly through emphases, associations, and omissions rather than explicit argumentation.

In this study, political framing is used to analyze how gender equality is discursively constructed in domestic official discourse. The analysis focuses on how state actors define gender-related problems, emphasize particular causes or obstacles, invoke specific values and principles, and legitimize certain policy responses or governance

approaches. Framing thus provides a discursive arena through which the domestic interpretation and localization of global gender norms can be analytically observed and examined.

3.4 Discursive politics of gender norms

(a) understanding why localization might differ between countries

Building on the framing approach developed above, this section turns to the discursive politics of international gender norms, outlining several theoretical perspectives on why and how localization may vary across contexts. Importantly, it does not seek to establish causal predictions about how China and India will differ, the section highlights broader analytical dimensions that may shape the domestic localization of global gender norms, such as political context, identity, and concerns about sovereignty.

Research on norm diffusion has not only shown that global norms are framed differently (and matter unevenly) across contexts – it has delineated expectations for how norm interpretations may vary and has suggested possible explanations for this variation. For instance, Acharya (2004) highlights the role of pre-existing domestic normative orders, while Gurowitz (1999; 2006) argues that the domestic impact of international norms is shaped by political struggle, identity, and institutional settings. More specifically, Acharya's argument about pre-existing domestic normative orders is supported by empirical research on gender and LGBTQ rights politics, which shows that universal rights claims gain traction only when articulated through locally resonant frames that enhance domestic legitimacy (Ayoub & Harris, 2025). Gurowitz (2006) further shows that states differ in their sensitivity to international judgments about normality, modernity, and status (see also Towns 2010, 2012). States that are more concerned with international recognition are more likely to mobilize global norms as symbols of international belonging, whereas states with more secure or alternative identity narratives may strategically reinterpret or contain such norms. These insights suggest that the domestic framing of gender norms is likely to vary

systematically across states with different identity orientations and international status concerns.

This perspective can be further specified by examining how historical contexts and cultural traditions shape national identity and may influence how international norms are differentially received. In postcolonial contexts such as India, Chatterjee (1993) argues that anticolonial nationalism produced a fundamental division between a "material" domain open to external influence and a "spiritual" domain representing national identity and resistant to external intervention (pp. 6-7). Norms associated with technology or development may therefore be more readily incorporated, while those perceived as intervening in the cultural foundations of national identity are more likely to be contested or selectively adapted. Crucially, gender relations occupy a particularly significant position within this framework, as nationalist discourse assigned women a symbolic role as bearers of cultural authenticity (Chatterjee, 1993, pp. 9-10).

These perspectives highlight identity, political context, and sovereignty concerns as dimensions that may shape how gender equality is framed and global gender norms are localized, but they are used here as analytical orientations rather than causal predictions, informing the empirical analysis that follows.

(b) a typology of domestic frames shaping gender norm localization

Frames are interpretive filters that structure how global norms are justified, adapted, or contested in national discourse (Acharya, 2004; Cortell & Davis, 1996; Entman, 1993). This section develops a theoretical typology of domestic frames through which global gender norms acquire political meaning by being attached to domestic gender issues and narratives. The typology distinguishes between five analytically distinct frames – developmental and instrumental; national cultural identity; security and protection; international status; and justice and rights. The typology helps me identify both *which frames* are predominant and to subsequently analyze *in what ways* the

overarching frame is given contextual meaning. Table 3.4. provides an overview of the five domestic frames, each of which is described more fully in the subsections that follow.

Table 3.4. Typology of Domestic Frames in Gender Norm Localization

Frame	Gender norms are framed in terms of...
Developmental & instrumental	... economic growth and development outcomes.
National cultural identity	... cultural tradition and national identity.
Security & protection	...protection of women, families, and social stability.
International status	... international legitimacy, status, and state prestige.
Justice & rights	... individual justice and rights in its own right, rather than as a means to other political goals.

(1) Developmental and instrumental framing

The first frame interprets gender norms primarily in developmental and instrumental terms. Here, gender inequality is defined less as a problem of social injustice than as a barrier to economic growth and development outcomes. Using the framing in *World Development Report 2012* as an illustration, gender equality is presented a problem for development because women's participation affects productivity, economic performance, and institutional effectiveness (World Bank, 2012, p. 3). The problem in this framing concerns development, rather than, say, the suffering of women as such. Indeed, the motivating problem underlying this framing emphasizes development effectiveness and economic rationality.

Gender inequalities thus become framed as a cause of the problem rather than the problem as such, often framed in terms of the underuses or misallocation of women's labor, skills, and resources, as this generates economic losses and weakens development outcomes. In this framing, the causes of these gender disparities are, in turn, typically attributed to structural barriers in markets and institutions, including unequal access to productive inputs, employment opportunities, credit, and assets,

resulting in persistent gaps in productivity and earnings (World Bank, 2012, pp. 16–18).

If gender disparities are a cause of development problems, promoting women's productivity becomes the solution. As Chant and Sweetman (2012) note, contemporary development discourse increasingly presents gender equality as “smart economics,” framing (or justifying) investment in women and girls as a means of generating broader social and economic returns (p. 518). Women are often portrayed as constrained yet especially valuable development actors. Accordingly, policy responses focus on integrating gender equality into development strategies, expanding women’s educational and economic opportunities, and reducing institutional barriers that limit their participation in markets and governance (World Bank, 2012).

(2) National cultural identity framing

The second frame interprets gender norms as a problem for national cultural identity, presenting national unity and national cultural tradition as important overarching goals. Within this framing, gender relations are framed primarily in terms of cultural tradition and national belonging, rather than e.g., a matter of development or the individual rights to human dignity of women, girls, and gender minorities. Studies of nationalism show that discourses of national identity are frequently gendered, linking particular roles, virtues, and social expectations to ideals of the nation and its members (Hogan, 2009, pp. 1–2).

Global gender norms are therefore often represented as a cause of a problem, i.e., the erosion of cultural norms or the intrusion of foreign values into national society. For instance, contemporary anti-gender movements and far-right actors often portray gender equality and LGBTQ rights as externally imposed “gender ideology” that threatens traditional family structures and moral order (Lombardo, Kantola, & Rubio-Marín, 2021, pp. 521–522). Such narratives have become central to broader illiberal political projects that mobilize opposition to feminism, sexual minorities, and

progressive equality policies. In some cases, gender equality initiatives are depicted as symbols of moral decay associated with liberal Western societies, reinforcing narratives of cultural decline and social disorder (Brock & Askanius, 2023, pp. 96–97).

The solution to the problem is also framed in terms of nationalist goals. In Taiwan, for example, conservative groups mobilized opposition to marriage equality by invoking the defense of the family and Confucian cultural values (Lai, 2025, pp. 424–426), while in several African contexts political elites portray LGBTQ rights as “foreign” or “un-African” impositions to justify restrictive policies (Ayoub & Harris, 2025, pp. 1–3).

(3) Security and protection framing

A third frame interprets gender norms as a matter of security and protection, linking gender issues to concerns about public safety and the protection of vulnerable groups. Within this frame, the central problem is that women and girls are exposed to harm, including violence, sexual abuse, harassment, trafficking, and other forms of gender-based harm, that threatens their safety and broader social stability.

The causes of these problems are typically attributed to discrete criminal incidents, social risks, and failures of individual officials, institutions, or enforcement mechanisms to prevent and regulate such harms.

Framing gender-related challenges as security deficits requiring regulatory intervention by the state (Kapur, 2013, pp. 317–319). As feminist scholarship has shown, such narratives frequently construct women as vulnerable subjects in need of rescue while legitimizing the authority of those who claim the role of protector (Abu-Lughod, 2002, pp. 783–784). The values invoked here emphasize protection, hierarchy, and paternal responsibility. Young (2003) argues that protection discourses

reflect the logic of "masculinist protection," in which those who offer protection claim authority while those protected, typically women, concede a degree of decision-making autonomy in return (pp. 2-4). Consequently, policy responses within this frame prioritize protective and regulatory measures, including strengthened criminal legislation, policing, or security interventions. As Kapur (2013) shows in her analysis of India, gender and sexuality are increasingly governed through a "sexual security regime," in which the state expands regulatory authority over gender relations in the name of protection (pp. 317-319). Gender relations are largely depicted as matters of security governance, in which the state is expected to safeguard vulnerable groups from harm.

(4) International status framing

A fourth frame interprets gender norms through concerns about international status. Within this framing, the central problem is not gender inequality as such, but a state's perceived deficit in international standing, modernity, or recognition. Gender-related policies therefore become indicators of where a state stands in global hierarchies. As Towns (2010, 2012) argues, international norms do not merely standardize state behavior but also generate hierarchical rankings among states, defining which practices are associated with being "normal" or "desirable" (pp. 179-180). Gender-related policies may thus be framed as indicators of a state's modernity and international standing.

The causes of the status problem may be framed as located in reputational gaps or insufficient recognition rather than in domestic gender inequality itself. For instance, higher levels of women's legislative representation are often interpreted as signs that a country belongs to a "modern" and high status group of states (Towns, 2012, p. 183). The values underlying this framing emphasize international legitimacy, prestige, and recognition.

States may therefore promote gender equality policies as a way of demonstrating national progress and signaling their aspiration for higher status within global hierarchies. Carvalho Pinto (2019) likewise shows that the United Arab Emirates has explicitly promoted women's rights as part of a status-signalling strategy aimed at persuading international audiences that the state deserves a higher position in the international order (pp. 345-347). Accordingly, policy responses within this frame often involve publicly promoting gender equality achievements, increasing women's political representation, or incorporating gender equality into foreign policy agendas. In recent years, a growing number of "women-friendly states" have integrated gender equality into diplomacy and development policy, framing the advancement of women's rights and empowerment as part of "smart diplomacy" (Aggestam & True, 2020, p. 144).

(5) Justice and rights framing

The fifth frame interprets gender equality as a matter of social justice and fundamental human rights of individuals, rather than framing gender equality as a means to other political goals.

Within this framing, gender inequality is understood as the problem; a form of structural injustice and rights violation, embedded in unequal power relations across both public and private spheres. This perspective may also define the problem as the persistence of gender-based disadvantage despite formal equality. As Fredman and Goldblatt (2015) note, the traditional principle of equal treatment is limited, since "equal treatment... might simply entrench that disadvantage," showing that gender equality cannot be secured through formal equality alone (p. 4). Gender inequality is therefore understood as a structural condition affecting women's access to resources, opportunities for participation, and dignity, rather than a matter of isolated discrimination.

The origins of this inequality is typically framed as residing in institutional and social arrangements that systematically reproduce gendered exclusion. The solutions to this problem is typically framed in terms of the state's obligation to uphold women's rights. Gender equality is given a "normative basis" that is "obligatory for States" (Powell, 2005, p. 607). Accordingly, the policy response associated with this frame emphasizes rights-protecting and transformative measures to promote substantive equality. Substantive equality may be framed as redressing disadvantage, countering stigma and violence, transforming unequal structures, and facilitating women's agency and participation (Fredman and Goldblatt 2015, pp. 5, 8-10).

3.5 Summary of the theoretical framework

This chapter has developed a theoretical framework for analyzing how gender equality is framed in domestic official discourse, laying the groundwork for the empirical examination of how global gender norms are localized in China and India. Drawing on a constructivist lens, the framework treats norm diffusion as an interpretive and context-dependent process in which the meaning of global gender norms is shaped through domestic framing rather than uniformly internalized.

Building on the literature on norm localization, the chapter identifies multiple factors that may mediate the domestic impact of global norms, including identity, political context, and concerns about sovereignty and status. These dimensions serve as an interpretive backdrop for the empirical analysis, not as explanatory variables requiring further theoretical examination, as such examination lies beyond the scope of this study.

To explain how this localization operates in practice, the framework adopts political framing as the central analytical mechanism, drawing on Entman's (1993) approach. Framing structures how gender equality acquires political meaning in domestic contexts by shaping problem definitions, causal interpretations, value justifications, and policy responses. On this basis, and drawing on insights from the discursive

politics of gender norms, the chapter develops a typology of five domestic frames, namely developmental and instrumental, national cultural identity, security and protection, international status, and justice and rights. Together, these frames provide a structured set of analytical lenses for identifying how gender equality is constructed in official discourse and which dimensions of global gender norms are emphasized, sidestepped, or bounded in the process.

Table 3.5 synthesizes the five frames by specifying their core logic across four analytical dimensions (i.e., problem diagnosis, causal interpretation, motivating values, and policy response).

Table 3.5. Typology of Domestic Frames in Gender Equality Discourse

Frames	Problem	Cause	Value	Response
Developmental and instrumental	Economic growth and development outcomes	Gender inequalities, cause by structural barriers in markets and institutions; underutilization of women's labor and skills etc	Productivity, economic rationality, development effectiveness	Integrating gender equality into development strategies; expanding women's economic and educational opportunities
National cultural identity	Erosion of cultural tradition and national values; intrusion of foreign norms	External imposition of "gender ideology"; Westernization; threat to traditional family and moral order	National unity, cultural authenticity, tradition, sovereignty	Defending traditional family structures; restricting progressive gender norms; promoting culturally grounded gender roles
Security and protection	Threats to women, families, and social stability	Discrete criminal conduct, insufficient state regulation, and social risks rather than structural patriarchal power	Protection, social order, paternal responsibility, state authority	Strengthened criminal legislation, policing, and regulatory intervention
International status	Reputational deficit; insufficient international recognition of modernity and	Failure to align with international standards; gender gaps as indicators of backwardness	International legitimacy, prestige, national progress	Publicly promoting gender equality achievements; increasing women's political representation;

	progress			gender-sensitive foreign policy
Justice and rights	Injustices and rights violations of women	Institutional and social arrangements that systematically reproduce gendered exclusion and patriarchal power	Human dignity, equality, justice, substantive rights	Rights-protecting and transformative measures; substantive equality across public and private spheres

4. Research Design & Methods: A Qualitative Text Analysis

This chapter explains how the research question of the thesis will be addressed and how the empirical analysis is conducted. The study examines how global gender norms are selectively localized through official framings of gender equality in China and India, treating both countries as valuable empirical sites for analyzing how rising powers engage with global gender norms discursively at home, while remaining attentive to shared patterns and context-specific differences. The chapter first presents the research design and explains the selection of China and India as analytically relevant cases, including the time frame analyzed (2015–2025). It then discusses the data sources and collection strategy, focusing on official political texts produced by governments and state-run media. The final section introduces the analytical method, which combines Carol Bacchi's 'What's the Problem Represented to Be?' approach with the framing typology developed in Chapter 3, whereby the framing typology is turned into analytical questions that will be systematically posed to the official texts.

4.1 Research Design

4.1.1 Case selection: *China and India*

The selection of China and India is empirically motivated. Both countries are widely recognized as rising powers in global politics. Over the past decades, China and India have experienced significant economic growth and increasing influence in global governance institutions (Hurrell, 2013, p. 203). Existing scholarship shows that rising

powers such as China and India are no longer peripheral rule-takers but increasingly consequential actors in global governance, with growing influence over institutional agendas and normative debates (Stephen, 2014, p. 913). How these states discursively frame international gender norms at home, including how they address its overarching dimensions and selectively engage with its more specific normative commitments, is therefore of particular analytical interest, as these framing choices are likely to shape both the domestic gender landscape and the global development of these norms.

Both China and India have formally engaged with global gender norms through their participation in major international agreements and policy frameworks. Both countries were among the early signatories of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) in 1980 (United Nations Treaty Collection, 2026). In addition, both governments endorsed the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action adopted at the Fourth World Conference on Women in 1995, which remains a central international agenda for advancing gender equality. Such engagement provides an empirical basis for examining how global gender norms are interpreted and localized in their domestic political discourse (UN Women, 1995).

At the same time, China and India differ significantly in their political settings, which may shape how global gender norms are framed domestically. China is widely analysed as an authoritarian party-state, even where scholars emphasize increasing pluralization within the policy process (Mertha, 2009), whereas India has long been seen as the world's largest democracy, with competitive elections and considerable social and political pluralism, though scholars have noted growing pressures on its democratic politics over the past decade (Varshney, 2019). In this thesis, however, this contrast is treated as an important background condition that may shape the institutional style of official communication, the relationship between state and society, the degree of discursive centralization, and the kinds of political values through which gender issues are justified. This also reflects the theoretical framework developed in Chapter 3, where differences in domestic institutions and state – society

relations are understood to condition how international norms become politically salient.

In sum, China and India are selected as empirically significant cases because together they provide fruitful sites for examining how global gender norms are framed within two distinct yet globally consequential domestic contexts. Including two cases allows the study to move beyond a single national setting and to examine how major rising powers with different political settings engage with global gender norms, what shared or divergent patterns emerge, and what this may say about the future direction of these norms.

4.1.2 Time frame of analysis: 2015-2025

The thesis examines China's and India's current framing, during the period 2015-2025. This temporal scope captures the most recent phase of global gender governance following the adoption of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which established gender equality as a central pillar of the contemporary global development agenda (United Nations, 2015). It also coincides with the most recent cycle of global reviews of the Beijing Platform for Action conducted by the UN Commission on the Status of Women (UN Women, 2020). Beginning the analysis in 2015 therefore provides a clear analytical starting point for examining how contemporary global gender norms are interpreted and framed in national political discourse. At the same time, recent scholarship identifies anti-gender politics as a new phase in global struggles around gender equality. Graff and Korolczuk argue that anti-gender campaigns, which initially gained visibility in Europe around 2010, have developed into a broader transnational movement challenging feminist and LGBTQ rights (Graff & Korolczuk, 2022, pp. 1–3).

Against this backdrop, examining China and India in this period is valuable because it extends a debate that has largely focused on Europe and populist politics to the context of rising powers, asking how global gender norms are interpreted within

domestic official discourse beyond the settings that have so far received the most scholarly attention. Overall, the chosen period provides a suitable temporal scope for examining contemporary discursive patterns and potential shifts in the official gender discourse of China and India.

4.2 Data sources and corpus delimitation: official state texts

This study draws on qualitative textual data from official state discourse in China and India. The choice of data follows directly from the research question, which concerns how governments frame global gender norms for domestic audiences, rather than how such norms are debated across society more broadly. In line with the interpretive focus of the thesis, the empirical material is therefore designed to capture authoritative and institutionalized articulations of gender-related norms within domestic official discourse.

The choice of textual sources also follows methodological principles of discourse analysis. As Neumann (2008) argues, discourse analysts examine “utterances,” which often appear as texts through which meanings and representations are produced in specific contexts (Neumann, 2008, p. 63). In political settings, such texts often include institutional documents, policy papers, speeches, official statements, and other forms of official political communication.

Importantly, discourse analysis – including framing analysis – is concerned not only with moments of explicit contestation, but also with how “realities” are maintained by the frequent repetition and confirmation of representations in political communication (Neumann, 2008, pp. 66–67). The corpus therefore includes both texts from key moments in which gender issues receive heightened political attention and more routine official texts, and it is delimited to what Neumann describes as a “wide but manageable range of sources” (Neumann, 2008, p. 63).

To operationalize this approach, the material is restricted to texts produced by actors located within the political executive, administrative, and official communication apparatuses of the Chinese and Indian states. This delimitation reflects the fact that official discourse is typically produced across multiple institutional levels rather than by a single state actor. Broad political priorities are commonly formulated at the level of heads of government, cabinets, and ministers, while ministries and other administrative bodies play a central role in developing policy content, translating these priorities into policy categories, implementation frameworks, and governance language (OECD/SIGMA, 2007, pp. 10–13, 34). Government communication is in turn linked to the policy process from an early stage, with coordination with the media helping to relay and reinforce these positions for wider domestic audiences (OECD/SIGMA, 1996, pp. 3–4).

The corpus is in two languages reflecting the official communication practices of each country. The Indian texts are in English, which holds official language status in India and serves as the primary medium of central government communication and official media such as the Press Information Bureau.^[7] The Chinese texts are in Mandarin Chinese; as a native Mandarin speaker, I am able to work with these materials in the original language and interpret their political and linguistic nuances directly without relying on translation.

Organised by actor and institutional function, the dataset includes two main groups of texts. First, it includes texts issued by the top political executive and central state institutions, such as major speeches, national plans, state council programmes, and other high-level statements issued by government or party-state authorities. These texts are especially important because they articulate broad political priorities, define nationally authoritative problem framings, and signal the values through which gender issues are justified.

[7] English is recognized as an associate official language under India's Official Languages Act, 1963, and functions as the primary language of central government communication, legislation, and official media. The Press Information Bureau publishes almost exclusively in English for central government communication.

Second, the corpus includes official communication texts disseminated through state-run or government-affiliated communication channels, insofar as they reiterate, publicize, or interpret official positions on gender-related issues. In comparative politics and media studies, media systems are generally understood in relation to political systems rather than as autonomous spheres detached from governance structures. Hallin and Mancini, for example, treat the relation between media and political systems as central to comparative analysis and distinguish different patterns of media, from the stronger role of market mechanisms in the Liberal Model to the closer integration of media into party politics and the stronger role of the state in the Polarized Pluralist Model (Hallin & Mancini, 2004).

This category therefore requires particular care in a comparison between China and India, since the institutional role of media differs across political settings. In democratic settings, journalism is normatively associated with a watchdog role, disclosing wrongdoing, and helping hold power accountable (Karadimitriou et al., 2022, pp. 101–102). In authoritarian settings, by contrast, media institutions may also function as part of the broader apparatus of governance and legitimation. As Stockmann and Gallagher show in the Chinese case, the media can contribute to regime legitimacy and effective rule, and even marketized media continue to operate within the constraints of censorship and an official line (Stockmann & Gallagher, 2011, pp. 436–437). Accordingly, in China, selected texts from outlets such as People's Daily and Xinhua are included not as 'media' in a broad societal sense, but as channels through which official positions are circulated and reiterated within the wider party-state communication structure. In India, by contrast, the corpus is not extended to the wider media sphere, but restricted to official government communication channels, above all the Press Information Bureau (PIB), which serves as the Central Government's nodal agency for disseminating information on government policies and programmes, and as an interface between government and media (PIB, 2025, pp. 4, 8). For this reason, PIB materials are included as official government communication texts, while independent or broader media reporting in India is excluded from the corpus.

Notably, although the corpus focuses on domestic official discourse, a very small number of texts are outward-facing in orientation – delivered in international forums (e.g., Global Women's Summit) or at multilateral summits (e.g., G20 Conference). These are included because they were subsequently circulated through official state media and government communication channels, forming an important part of the domestic official communication landscape on gender. The corpus does not, however, extend to line ministry or administrative texts beyond these two categories. While ministerial and sectoral policy documents are an important part of governance, their inclusion would substantially expand the corpus while introducing highly technical and implementation-focused material that is less directly relevant to analyzing the political framing of gender norms at the level of authoritative political communication. Where such materials are directly relevant – for example, scheme guidelines or policy announcements on gender – they are included only where they appear through official communication channels such as PIB, and are treated as Type II texts accordingly.

The data collection covers the period 2015–2025, comprising 17 texts for each country (34 texts in total). For India, the corpus includes 7 texts from Type I sources and 10 texts from Type II sources. For China, the corpus includes 10 texts from Type I sources and 7 texts from Type II sources. A detailed list of all corpus texts, including full source information, and the coding tables used in the empirical analysis, are provided in the Appendix (Table A1&2).

4.3 Analytical Method: Bacchi WPR Approach and Framing Typology

This study adopts a qualitative text analysis, combining Carol Bacchi's "What's the Problem Represented to be?" (WPR) approach with my framing typology developed on the basis of Entman's framing elements to analyse how official texts and speeches frame the issue under study. The aim is to examine not only how problems are represented, but also which frames organize these representations and what policy implications they produce.

4.3.1 Bacchi's WPR Approach: Analysing Problem Representations

Carol Bacchi's WPR approach starts from the premise that policies do not simply respond to problems but actively construct them, shaping how social realities are understood. Instead of assuming that policies simply respond to pre-existing problems, Bacchi argues that policy proposals themselves contain explicit or implicit representations of the problems they seek to address (Bacchi, 2016, p.5). These representations are not trivial, since they structure how "realities" are politically understood and shape the forms of governance that are rendered legitimate. In this respect, her understanding of problem representation is closely related to the concept of framing.

In its full form, the WPR approach consists of six analytical questions and a final reflexive step,^[8] and Bacchi and Goodwin explicitly describe it as a heuristic rather than a rigid procedural sequence (Bacchi & Goodwin, 2016, pp. 21–22). The present study does not directly apply the full set of WPR questions in the empirical analysis. Instead, it retains the core logic of Bacchi's approach and her suggestion to pose analytical questions systematically to the texts that are analyzed, while adapting this insight into a more focused set of questions suited to a comparative study of official framing. This reflects the specific aim of the study: rather than conducting a full poststructural analysis of policy discourse in terms of assumptions, historical formation, silences, effects, and contestation (Bacchi & Goodwin, 2016), the analysis seeks to identify and compare recurring patterns in how official texts frame gender-related problems, attribute causes, invoke values, and justify particular policy responses across the material. In this sense, the method used here is best understood as a WPR-informed framing analysis.

^[8] Bacchi and Goodwin's WPR framework includes the following questions: (1) What is the problem represented to be? (2) What presuppositions or assumptions underlie this representation? (3) How has this representation come about? (4) What is left unproblematic or silent within it? (5) What effects does this representation produce? (6) How and where has it been produced, disseminated, and defended, and how might it be disrupted? The seventh step (7) asks analysts to apply the same questions reflexively to their own problem representations (Bacchi & Goodwin, 2016, pp. 22–26).

Nonetheless, the study retains one further dimension of Bacchi's approach that proves productive for the analysis: attention to what is left unaddressed or silenced in official representations (Bacchi, 2016, p. 5). As Bacchi and Goodwin (2016) argue, 'what is not said' is as analytically significant as what is present – silences and omissions define the boundaries of legitimate political discourse and foreclose certain policy responses and subject positions (Bacchi & Goodwin, 2016, pp. 24–25). In this study, attention to what official texts do not say, and specifically which dimensions of international gender norms are systematically absent, marginalized, or rendered inadmissible, forms an important part of the comparative analysis in Chapter 5.

4.3.2 Analytical Questions and Coding Strategy

The empirical analysis is guided by the framing framework introduced in Chapter 3, which identifies five frame categories (developmental, cultural, protective, status and/or rights) and four analytical dimensions in official discourse (problem definition, causal diagnosis, value justification, and policy response). Accordingly, each text is read and coded through four corresponding questions:

- *What is the problem framed to be?*
- *What causes or obstacles are emphasized?*
- *What values, principles, or justifications are invoked?*
- *What policy responses or governance approaches are legitimised?*

Table 4.3. Analytical questions and indicative frame cues

Analytical dimension	Guiding question	Indicative frame cues
Problem definition	What is the problem framed to be?	development barriers; cultural threat; threats to safety/social stability; lack of international recognition/status; injustice or denial of rights
Causal diagnosis	What causes or obstacles are	underdevelopment or exclusion; foreign influence or moral decay; violence/insecurity; low international

	emphasized?	standing or weak visibility; discrimination or structural inequality
Value justification	What values or principles are invoked?	development and efficiency; tradition and national identity; protection and stability; legitimacy and prestige; justice and rights
Policy response	What policy responses or governance approaches are legitimised?	capacity-building and inclusion; identity preservation and value reinforcement; protective regulation and state intervention; status signalling and national representation; rights protection and legal reform

These questions are posed systematically to the collected texts in order to examine the modes of official framing across the Chinese and Indian corpora. This strategy is primarily deductive, in the sense that the frame typology developed in Chapter 3 provides the initial conceptual categories for analysis. At the same time, the reading of the texts remains interpretive and inductive. The analysis does not assume in advance exactly how a given frame will appear in practice, but explores how each frame is articulated, combined, or modified in specific national contexts. This makes it possible not only to identify whether a text draws on developmental, cultural, protective, status-related, or rights-based logics, but also to analyse more deeply how those logics are given concrete domestic meaning.

Importantly, this analytical framework does not assume that each text maps neatly onto a single frame. As Bacchi and Goodwin (2016, p. 23) note, policy texts are often complex constructions that may well involve more than one problem representation, and Entman (1993, p.52) emphasizes that frames may be constituted through partial combinations of framing elements. Multiple frames may therefore coexist within the same text, and not every frame is expected to contain all four dimensions explicitly. Where one frame more clearly organizes the overall logic of a text across all four analytical dimensions, it is described as dominant; where a frame develops a recognizable logic but remains secondary to the dominant one, it is described as

auxiliary. The reading of the corpus is systematic, attending to recurring patterns within and across texts.

5. Empirical Analysis: Framing Global Gender Norms in China and India

This chapter examines how China and India engage with international gender norms in domestic official discourse between 2015 and 2025. The central analytical focus is on how global normative commitments to gender equality are selectively interpreted, emphasized, or bounded as they are taken up in authoritative state gender narratives. It first maps the core dimensions of international gender norms relevant to the analysis, then provides a distributional overview of framing tendencies in each case, before turning to a closer interpretive examination of the Indian and Chinese corpora. The final section draws together findings from both cases and discusses their implications for the future trajectory of global gender norms.

In the analysis, particular attention is paid to how gender-related problems are constructed, which political values are invoked, and which dimensions of global gender norms are emphasized or left unaddressed. In sum, as the analysis below will show, several broader patterns emerge across the two cases. Gender equality is broadly affirmed and closely connected to development, governance, national projects, and social stability. Developmental framing is dominant in both cases, although articulated through different political logics. In India, gender norms are linked mainly to women-led development, welfare inclusion, and constitutional democracy. In China, they are embedded within national rejuvenation, Party leadership, and socialist modernization. Neither case substantially engages with reproductive autonomy or sexual orientation and gender identity (SOGI), revealing a broader pattern of selective omission.

5.0 International gender norms: spectrum and core dimensions

International gender norms have largely developed through international treaties and United Nations policy frameworks, particularly CEDAW, the Beijing Platform for Action, and the Sustainable Development Goals. Clarifying the main dimensions of these norms provides the basis for examining how China and India engage with international gender norms in domestic discourse, including which dimensions are incorporated, how they are framed, and which issues remain marginalized or absent.

CEDAW (1979) constitutes a central pillar of the international gender regime. Widely regarded as the key international treaty on women's rights, CEDAW affirms that gender-based discrimination "violates the principles of equality of rights and respect for human dignity" and establishes gender equality and non-discrimination as fundamental principles across political, economic, social, cultural, and family life (CEDAW, Arts. 1–3). CEDAW also significantly extends international gender norms into domains historically treated as private or culturally specific, including reproduction, family relations, and household responsibilities. The Convention addresses women's reproductive decision-making and access to family planning (CEDAW, Arts. 12 and 16), while also emphasizing shared responsibilities between men and women within the family structure (CEDAW, Art. 5). These provisions laid an important foundation for later frameworks concerning sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHR), which increasingly linked reproductive autonomy, healthcare, and bodily integrity to broader understandings of gender equality.

The Beijing Platform for Action (1995) consolidated and further expanded global gender norms by transforming earlier treaty commitments into a more comprehensive policy and governance agenda. The Platform identified 12 critical areas of concern, including violence against women, women's health, economic participation, political representation, education, and poverty (UN, 1995). One of its most influential contributions was the promotion of gender mainstreaming, which extended gender perspectives across policy areas and emphasized structural transformation. Subsequent developments within the United Nations system, particularly the

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), further integrated gender equality into global development governance. SDG 5 explicitly commits states to achieving gender equality and empowering all women and girls, connecting gender norms to broader dimensions of inclusiveness and sustainability (UN, 2015).

Together, these frameworks constitute a differentiated and evolving normative spectrum. Certain principles – particularly equality, non-discrimination, women’s empowerment, and protection from gender-based violence – have achieved relatively broad state endorsement. At the same time, other dimensions of international gender norms remain politically contested across contexts. These include reproductive autonomy, sexuality, family relations, and issues related to sexual orientation and gender identity (SOGI). Debates over abortion rights and the Istanbul Convention illustrate these tensions: the latter's definition of gender as socially constructed rather than biological has drawn criticism for promoting "gender ideology" and threatening traditional values (Krizsán et al., 2025, p. 2163).

5.1 Frame distribution across the Indian and Chinese corpora

Tables 5.1 provide an overview of frame distribution across the Indian (Panel A) and Chinese (Panel B) corpora respectively. Dominant frames are identified not by the frequency of keywords but by the relative centrality and coherence of a given framing logic across the construction of problems, causes, values, and policy responses in each text. The tables should therefore be read as interpretive overviews of broader framing patterns rather than quantitative measures of discourse.

Table 5.1 (A) Frame Distribution Across the Indian Corpus (2015–2025)

Note: 'Dominant' = the frame that most coherently organizes the problem, cause, value, and policy logic of a text. 'Appears as Auxiliary' = present as secondary logic in other texts. 'Total Presence' = dominant + auxiliary occurrences combined.

* All texts combine multiple frames; totals exceed 17.

Frame Category	Inductive Labels / Sub-themes	Dominant (n)	Appears as Auxiliary (n)	Total Presence (n)
Developmental & Instrumental	Growth multiplier; life-cycle empowerment; women-led national development	9*	8	17*
Security & Protection	Endangered girl child; safety as precondition for empowerment; welfare of marginalized groups	4	12	16*
Justice & Rights	Constitutional pride; legal recognition; non-discrimination; rights bounded by civic duties	4	11	15*
National Cultural Identity	Democratic pride; gender equality as national character	0	5	5
International Status	India as norm-contributor; women-led development as global concept	0	4	4

The Indian distribution points to three main tendencies. Developmental and instrumental framing is clearly dominant, organizing the primary logic of nine out of seventeen texts. Security and protection framing and justice and rights framing each appear as dominant in four texts, making them two comparably weighted secondary logics. National identity and international positioning never appear as dominant frames but recur as embedded peripheral frames across the corpus.

Table 5.1 Frame Distribution Across the Chinese Corpus (2015–2025)

Note: 'Dominant' = the frame that most coherently organizes the problem, cause, value, and policy logic of a text. 'Appears as Auxiliary' = present as secondary logic in other texts. 'Total Presence' = dominant + auxiliary occurrences combined.

* All texts combine multiple frames; totals exceed 17.

Frame Category	Inductive Labels / Sub-themes	Dominant (n)	Appears as Auxiliary (n)	Total Presence (n)
Developmental & Instrumental	Modernization & state planning; socialist achievement & international obligation	8*	9	17*
Party-led National Rejuvenation / Socialist Path	Political mobilization & ACWF building; socialist path with Chinese characteristics; resisting 'erroneous ideas'	4	6	10*
Justice & Rights / Legal Governance	Legal enforcement & rights protection; governance accountability legislative reform & non-discrimination	3	12	15*
International Status & Contribution	responsible major power; global norm-contributor; South-South cooperation; Beijing spirit	2	8	10
Security & Protection	Governance accountability for violence; protection of vulnerable groups	0	7	7

The Chinese distribution showcases four distinct framing patterns. Developmental and instrumental framing is again clearly dominant, organizing the primary logic of eight out of seventeen texts. Party-led national rejuvenation and the socialist path constitutes a second prominent frame, appearing as dominant in four texts – a logic with no equivalent in the Indian corpus. Justice & rights framing and international status & contribution framing appear as dominant in three and two texts respectively, both functioning more frequently as auxiliary logics across the corpus. Security and protection never appears as a dominant frame.

These distributional patterns indicate the main framing tendencies in each case but reveal little about how specific framing and language construct domestic gender discourse and the extent to which it engages with international gender norms – which

is the central concern of this study. Closer interpretive analysis of each corpus is therefore needed, and it is to this that the chapter now turns.

5.2 India: framing gender norms in domestic official discourse

The Indian corpus reveals a broadly affirmative engagement with gender equality and women's empowerment, consistently mediated through domestic priorities such as national development, welfare governance, and constitutional inclusion. Three framing patterns structure the corpus: a clearly dominant developmental frame, and two auxiliary frames of protection and justice-based constitutional inclusion.

5.2.1 Dominant frame: national development

The most visible frame across the corpus is developmental and instrumental. Across speeches, policy documents, scheme guidelines, and parliamentary addresses from 2015 to 2025, gender equality is made politically meaningful through its contribution to national progress.

Within this frame, the problem is India is not as developed as it could and should be, and gender inequality is portrayed as a constraint on national progress. Women are represented as an underutilized resource whose fuller participation is necessary for India's advancement. This framing is especially evident in official speeches on women's empowerment and entrepreneurship. As the Vice President stated in a speech on women's economic participation: ^[9] *"We cannot achieve a double digit growth without women's active participation."*

Central to this frame is the idea of a multiplier effect: women's empowerment is therefore justified through its wider returns to families, children, and society:

^[9] *"Women's active participation in decision-making has a positive impact on*

^[9] Vice President's Secretariat, 'Women Empowerment Is Not Only a National Goal but Also a Global Agenda' (PIB, 2018). <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1538730>

education, health, nutrition, employment and social protection... as female education levels rise, infant and child mortality rates fall and family health improves." A similar logic runs through a decade of official discourse, also evident in a G20 Ministerial address^[10], and a Rajya Sabha address^[11]. By 2024, the government openly stated,^[12] *"Today, it is not just about women's development but women-led development,"* which positions women not merely as recipients of support, but as active contributors to national progress.

The causes of gender inequality are typically diagnosed as barriers to participation: unequal access to credit, education, land, employment, and markets, as well as the burden of unpaid care work. A speech describes how women have not only been ^[9]*"disadvantaged in accessing not only material resources like property and credit," but also "deprived of resources like market information and business technologies."* Patriarchal mindsets and regressive customs are also named, though typically translated into calls to oppose and resist harmful attitudes - the deeper question of why patriarchal power persists and how it structurally excludes women remains largely unaddressed.

The proposed solutions follow from this diagnosis. The values invoked are productivity, entrepreneurship, and inclusive development. Policy responses focus on enabling women's participation in the economy: expanding financial access through Stand-Up India^[13] and MUDRA loans^[14], building skills through vocational training, establishing Working Women Hostels^[15], and promoting women's entrepreneurship

^[10] PM Modi, 'PM Addresses G20 Ministerial Conference on Women Empowerment' (PMO, 2023): "When women prosper, the world prospers... their economic empowerment fuels growth and their access to education drives global progress."

^[11] PM Modi, Reply to the Motion of Thanks on the President's Address in Rajya Sabha (PMO, 2025): "India's progress is powered by Nari Shakti (women's strength)."

^[12] Press Information Bureau, 'NARI SHAKTI: From Women Development to Women-led Development' (PIB, 2024).

^[13] Stand-Up India (2016) promotes women's entrepreneurship through guaranteed bank loans (PIB, 2021)

^[14] MUDRA (2015) provides micro-finance, with women accounting for almost 8 out of 10 accounts for loans under Rs. 50,000 (PIB, 2018).

^[15] Working Women Hostels is a sub-component of Mission Shakti's Samarthya empowerment stream, providing subsidized housing for working women alongside childcare support (PIB, 2022).

through digital inclusion initiatives. The remedy here, in short, is incorporation into development – improving women's access to existing economic structures rather than redistributing power or securing their substantive agency within them.

5.2.2 Auxiliary frame: protection of women and girls

Alongside the developmental frame, the corpus reflects a protection-oriented logic in which women and girls are represented as vulnerable groups exposed to pre-birth and post-birth discrimination, violence, or other harmful social practices. The central site of this frame is the Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao (BBBP) campaign,^[16] which foregrounds the declining Child Sex Ratio as its major concern – "the girl child is increasingly being excluded from life itself."^[17] – while also addressing girls' disadvantage across the life cycle.

The causes of this problem are diagnosed as primarily attitudinal. Modi identifies "a defect in our attitudes towards boys and girls"^[18] as the root cause, and another PIB document points to "son-centric rituals" and "socio-cultural and religious biases"^[17] as the driving forces behind the discrimination faced by girls from birth onwards. The underlying solution is therefore "behavioural change in society" through community engagement, awareness campaigns, and mass mobilization.^[17] The values framed around are moral duty and collective responsibility. Modi's BBBP launch address states: "To save the girl child, to educate the girl child, this is our social duty, cultural duty, and humanitarian responsibility."^[19] Such framing positions both society and the state as the agents of change, acting on behalf of the girl child.

^[16] Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao means 'Save the daughter, educate the daughter' in Hindi. The campaign was launched in 2015 in response to the declining Child Sex Ratio recorded in the 2011 Census (918 girls per 1,000 boys aged 0–6). Cited texts: PMO, 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' (2015); PMO, 'Special Episode of Mann Ki Baat' (2015); PIB, 'BBBP Scheme FAQ' (2022).

^[17] PIB, 'BBBP Scheme FAQ' (2022). <https://static.pib.gov.in/WriteReadData/userfiles/file/FAQ-BetiBachao,BetiPadhaoYojanaI3K2.pdf>

^[18] PMO, 'Special Episode of Mann Ki Baat' (2015). https://www.pmindia.gov.in/en/news_updates/english-rendering-of-transcript-of-the-special-episode-of-mann-ki-baat-pm-shri-narendra-modi-and-us-president-shri-barack-obama-share-their-thoughts-on-radio/

^[19] PMO, 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao: Caring for the Girl Child' (2015). https://www.pmindia.gov.in/en/government_tr_rec/beti-bachao-beti-padhao-caring-for-the-girl-child/

This protective logic is further institutionalized in Mission Shakti (2022), whose dual structure of Sambal (protection) and Samarthya (empowerment) integrates safety and economic participation under a single state framework, promising to make women "economically empowered, exercising free choice over their minds and bodies in an atmosphere free from violence and threat."^[20] Protection from gender-based violence is thus genuinely present, engaging CEDAW Art. 1 and SDG 5 – but the structural conditions sustaining discrimination, including institutional impunity for gender-based violence and the absence of legal recourse for violence within the family, remain largely unaddressed.

5.2.3 Auxiliary frame: justice and rights

Although less dominant than developmental narratives, the Indian corpus also contains a recurring rights and justice frame grounded in the constitutional spirit, though one that remains incomplete: rights are bounded by civic duties, women's reproductive autonomy and SRHR are absent, and SOGI-based rights appear only at the margins.

In this frame, gender inequality is a problem in its own right – the exclusion of women and marginalized groups from their rightful place in public and political life. State actors usually invoke constitutional pride and democratic values to make this case: Modi (2024) highlights that "while many other nations took decades to grant rights to women, Bharat ensured their right to vote right from the inception of its Constitution."^[21] Rights language, however, is consistently paired with duties to the country. Modi quotes Gandhi that "rights naturally flow from the faithful discharge of one's duties"^[21] and links the fulfilment of such duties directly to building a developed India - rights, in this regard, earned through responsible citizenship.

^[20] PIB, 'Mission Shakti Guidelines' (2022). <https://www.pib.gov.in/Pressreleaseshare.aspx?PRID=1885352>

^[21] PMO, 'PM's Address in Lok Sabha at the Special Discussion on the 75th Anniversary of the Adoption of the Constitution' (2024).

LGBTQ+ persons are also, if tentatively, drawn into this frame – though most references concern transgender persons specifically. The core problem is framed as social exclusion: transgender persons "rejected by their families and society"^[13] with limited access to skill development, healthcare and livelihood. The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019 provides legal recognition,^[14] with institutional measures including the SMILE scheme,^[15] shelter homes, and advisories mandating 'transgender' as a gender option in official forms.^[16] The government presents this as a rights commitment, yet the inclusion remains welfare-oriented and cautious, more substantive rights and liberal gender norms around same-sex marriage, property, and adoption go unaddressed.^[22]

In addition, two minor frames recur across the corpus, typically embedded within the three main frames rather than articulated independently. National identity appears as a background register: gender commitments are presented as flowing from India's own constitutional heritage and democratic tradition, and as compatible with the nation's self-understanding^[21]. International positioning surfaces similarly: India increasingly presents itself as a norm-contributor rather than a norm-taker, most explicitly through the introduction of 'women-led development' at the G20 and the establishment of a dedicated Working Group on Women's Empowerment under India's presidency^[10].

5.3 China: framing gender norms in domestic official discourse

The Chinese corpus reflects a highly state-led and politically centralized discourse in which gender equality is organized under Party authority and framed primarily through the language of socialist development and national rejuvenation.^[23] Four framing patterns structure the corpus: a dominant socialist development frame, a Party-led national rejuvenation frame unique to the Chinese case, and two auxiliary

^[22] Same-sex conduct was only decriminalized in 2018 (*Navtej Singh Johar v. Union of India*, AIR 2018 SC 4321), and rights around same-sex marriage, property, and adoption remain legally unrecognized — the corpus reflects this legal context.

^[23] National rejuvenation (民族复兴) refers to the political goal of restoring China's historical greatness following the 'century of humiliation' – the period from the First Opium War (1839) to the founding of the People's Republic (1949). Under Xi Jinping, it recurs as a prominent organizing theme across official political discourse.

frames of justice and rights and international status and contribution. The analysis presents each frame in turn before examining what they collectively leave unsaid.

5.3.1 Dominant frame: socialist development and national rejuvenation

Like India, the Chinese corpus is organized primarily around a developmental logic – but one more deeply embedded in socialist ideology and revolutionary heritage. Women are described as a vital collective force whose contribution to socialist construction and national renewal is indispensable. The Maoist formulation that women 'hold up half the sky'^[24] runs through the corpus as a mobilizing signal, encoding a productionist logic: women matter because national construction requires their labour and participation.

The problem is defined as the incomplete realization of women's potential limiting national development process. The 2021 China Women's Development Program (CWDP 2021–2030) situates its objectives within the strategic task of "advancing Chinese-style modernization," treating remaining gender disparities as "inconsistent with high-quality development goals."^[25] In a speech to the new ACWF^[26] leadership, Xi called on women to: "contribute more to building a modern socialist country and advancing the great rejuvenation."^[27] The causes are framed as developmental shortfalls – regional disparities, insufficient resources and public services. The 2025 Monitoring Report exemplifies this: gender gaps are tracked through technical development indicators – enrollment rates, maternal mortality, employment shares, scientific literacy scores,^[28] with no further account of why. This is not incidental – it

^[24] The phrase 'women hold up half the sky' (妇女能顶半边天) a slogan attributed to Mao Zedong, used from the revolutionary period to rally women into contributing to socialist construction. The formulation appears across the National Women's Congress addresses (2018, 2023) and Xi Jinping's global summit speeches (2015, 2025) in the corpus.

^[25] State Council of China, 'China Women's Development Program (2021–2030)' (国发〔2021〕16号, September 2021). <https://www.nhc.gov.cn/wjw/mtbd/202109/b8200caf662340eca566c842b07d8faa.shtml>

^[26] The All-China Women's Federation (全国妇女联合会, ACWF) is a Party-affiliated mass organization established in 1949. It operates under CCP leadership, simultaneously representing women to the Party and transmitting Party directives to women. It has no independent advocacy mandate.

^[27] Xinhua, 'Xi Jinping Meets the New Leadership of the All-China Women's Federation' (2023). https://www.gov.cn/yaowen/liebiao/202310/content_6912723.htm

^[28] National Bureau of Statistics, 'Statistical Monitoring Report on the Implementation of the China Women's Development Program (2021–2030)' (December 2025). https://www.stats.gov.cn/xgk/sjfb/zxfb2020/202512/t20251230_1962183.html

reflects a circular discursive pattern in which development is simultaneously the problem, the cause, and the cure, effectively sidestepping systemic patriarchal critique and liberal rights dimensions.

The values invoked are national strength, collective contribution, and modernization – women's advancement matters as a contribution to state goals, not as an end in itself. Policy responses are accordingly state-organized and planning-driven. The 2025 White Paper captures this logic plainly, stating that women's development targets are integrated into national five-year plans, with women's development level treated as "an important measure of the level of economic and social development," advancing in lockstep with the state's broader modernization agenda.^[29]

5.3.2 Auxiliary frame: party leadership and the socialist path

A second prominent frame links women's advancement to Party leadership and organizational building, requiring correct political direction. This frame is most visible in the National Women's Congress addresses – periodic gatherings of the ACWF system that function as both organizational events and demonstrations of Party authority over women's work. At the 12th National Women's Congress in 2018, Zhao Leji called for: "upholding the leadership of the Chinese Communist Party in women's work... ensuring the correct political direction of women's cause and the Women's Federation."^[30] The later address by Ding Xuexiang reiterates this, calling on women's organizations to "remain firmly aligned with the Party," "act in accordance with the Party Central Committee's decisions," and "unite women to follow the Party."^[31] Women are addressed not as autonomous individuals with rights and freedom, but as a mass group to be politically organized and aligned.

^[29] State Council Information Office, 'Practices and Achievements of Promoting Women's All-round Development in the New Era' [White Paper] (September 2025). http://www.scio.gov.cn/zfbps/ndhf/2025n_bps/202509/t20250923_932330.html

^[30] Xinhua, 'Address on Behalf of the CPC Central Committee at the Opening of the 12th National Women's Congress' (Zhao Leji, October 2018). <https://cpc.people.com.cn/n1/2018/1030/c64094-30371911.html>

^[31] Xinhua, 'Address on Behalf of the CPC Central Committee at the Opening of the 13th National Women's Congress' (Ding Xuexiang, October 2023). https://www.news.cn/2023-10/23/c_1129932345.htm

The ACWF^[26] is central to this frame. Xi's 2018 speech called for the Federation to "act as a bridge and link between the Party and women,"^[32] positioning it as a transmission belt rather than an independent advocate. Policy responses focus on strengthening the ACWF system and mobilizing women through Party-led channels. His 2023 ACWF speech goes further, explicitly warning against "erroneous ideas and viewpoints,"^[27] a signal directed against liberal feminist and Western gender discourse, increasingly framed in Chinese official media as extremist or ideologically threatening.^[33] Accordingly, feminist civil society, contentious gender politics, and independent women's organizing are not merely absent from official discourse, but actively foreclosed. Both CEDAW Art. 7(c) and the Beijing Platform for Action envision women's autonomous civic participation as central to gender equality;^[34] Chinese official framing moves, if implicitly, in the opposite direction.

5.3.3 Auxiliary frame: justice, rights, and legal governance

The corpus also contains a governance-oriented rights discourse centred on legal guarantees and state accountability. Official texts consistently describe gender equality as the "basic state policy" and women's rights as "basic human rights." The 2022 revision of the Law on the Protection of Women's Rights and Interests strengthened anti-discrimination and anti-harassment provisions and improved rural property rights for women,^[35] resonating with areas that CEDAW Arts. 11 and 16 directly address.^[36]

^[32] Xinhua, 'Xi Jinping Meets the New ACWF Leadership and Delivers an Important Speech' (November 2018). https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2018-11/02/content_5336958.htm

^[33] Since the mid-2010s, Chinese state media and official commentary have increasingly portrayed liberal feminism and LGBTQ+ rights discourse as forms of Western ideological infiltration. Feminist activists have faced account deletions, NGO closures, and in some cases detention. The '#MeToo' movement in China and the 2021 closure of several university feminist groups illustrate this pattern. See: Wang, F. (2022). Feminist activism under authoritarian constraint: China's #MeToo movement. *Gender & Society*, 36(2), 183–207.

^[34] CEDAW Art. 7(c) requires states to ensure women the right to participate in non-governmental organizations concerned with public and political life. The Beijing Platform for Action (Strategic Objective G.3) calls on governments to support NGOs advocating for women's rights as independent actors.

^[35] The Xuzhou chained woman case (丰县事件, February 2022): a woman was found chained in a shed in Feng County, Xuzhou, reportedly forced to bear eight children. The case triggered unprecedented national outrage on Chinese social media.

^[36] CEDAW Art. 11 addresses women's right to equal employment opportunities, equal pay, and protection from dismissal on grounds of pregnancy or marital status. Art. 16 addresses equal rights in marriage and family relations, including equal rights to property within marriage and the family.

The limits of this frame, however, become visible in the 2022 Xuzhou^[35] case: A woman was found chained in a shed, reportedly forced to bear eight children, triggering unprecedented national outrage. The problem is framed predominantly as a governance failure, with officials neglecting their duties and enforcement mechanisms falling short, sidestepping any recognition of structural gender-based violence and the entrenched patriarchal and coercive reproductive norms that sustain it. Invoking values of rule of law, social order, and state accountability, the remedy focused on accountability: the investigation penalized seventeen individuals and called for stricter anti-trafficking measures.^[37]

5.3.4 Auxiliary frame: international status and contribution

A fourth frame positions China as a norm-contributor rather than a norm-taker in global gender governance, most visible in Xi's speeches at the Global Women's Summits. The problem is framed as a global one: persistent gender inequality threatens peace and development, and China has both a responsibility and a model to offer. Xi proposed a four-point initiative on development, rights protection, inclusive culture, and international cooperation.^[Error! Bookmark not defined.] and pledged to "contribute Chinese wisdom and Chinese solutions"³⁸ to global gender governance.^[31] The 2019 White Paper^[39] reinforces this, invoking CEDAW, the Beijing Platform for Action, and the SDGs to document progress and showcase achievements, – yet more contested dimensions of global gender norms find no mention, and there is no indication of further normative agenda-setting. Despite invoking the 'Beijing spirit' and global responsibility, the concrete initiatives proposed, including digital

^[37] Xinhua, 'Investigation into the Xuzhou Woman with Eight Children Case' (February 2022). https://www.news.cn/2022-02/23/c_1128408829.htm

^[38] In this context, references to "Chinese wisdom" and "Chinese solutions" point to a state-led and development-oriented, and pragmatic approach to gender governance, reflected across the corpus through repeated emphasis on poverty reduction, education, employment, social stability, and national modernization as central pathways to women's advancement.

^[39] State Council Information Office, 'Equality, Development and Sharing: Progress of Women's Cause in China over the Past 70 Years' [White Paper] (September 2019). <http://politics.people.com.cn/n1/2019/0919/c1001-31362781.html>. The only corpus text to cite CEDAW, the Beijing Platform for Action, and SDGs simultaneously in a domestic publication.

inclusion, technological support, and South-South cooperation, are nonetheless firmly situated within the developmental register.

What's more, unlike India, where security and protection framing constitutes a prominent auxiliary frame organized around the girl child, security concerns in the Chinese corpus appear only as an embedded logic, surfacing in the context of trafficking accountability (Xuzhou case), conflict-affected women in global speeches, and marginalized groups in development planning, and never as a dominant or independently elaborated frame.

5.4 Comparative analysis and implications

The preceding analysis reveals both important convergences and significant differences in how global gender norms are framed in Chinese and Indian official discourse.

The most striking convergence is the dominance of developmental framing in both cases. Across both sets of texts, gender equality is made politically meaningful primarily through its contribution to national progress – women matter primarily as productive participants. Both states also position the state as the central and overwhelmingly dominant agent of gender governance, marginalizing autonomous feminist mobilization, civil society advocacy, and critical feminist politics. What CEDAW and the Beijing Platform for Action envision as essential mechanisms of gender equality, namely independent women's organizations and feminist movements, find little to no place in either set of official statements. Both also assert normative innovation in global gender governance, advancing a pragmatic and predominantly economic vision of women's advancement: India through "women-led development,"^[12] China through "Chinese wisdom and Chinese solutions."^[38]

The differences are equally significant. India's framing is more pluralistic: it incorporates constitutional rights language, partial recognition of LGBTQ+ communities, and more explicit references to international frameworks. India's omissions are largely structural – developmental framing crowds out rights-based approaches without explicitly prohibiting them. China's framing is more uniformly bounded: the Party-led frame is distinctive, feminist civil society and LGBTQ+ rights are actively foreclosed rather than merely absent, and the boundaries of legitimate gender discourse are explicitly policed.

Both framings, nevertheless, share a consistent profile of selective omission: reproductive autonomy and SRHR, SOGI-based rights, men's role in gender equality, and feminist critique of patriarchal power are absent from both. These are not peripheral dimensions of international gender norms – they are among its most substantive commitments. Their systematic absence suggests that what is being omitted is structurally determined: these are the dimensions of global gender norms that most directly challenge state authority over bodies, families, and civil society.

This pattern carries concrete implications for international gender norms. Both India and China are growing in geopolitical weight and multilateral influence, active in the G20, the CSW, and the Beijing+30 process, and both increasingly assert normative influence rather than compliance. If two states representing over a third of humanity consistently advocate for developmental and statist interpretations of gender equality while sidelining more substantive and liberal rights dimensions, the cumulative effect may be a quiet dilution of international norms and their influential reach. Not through direct opposition, but through the gradual normalization of a more conservative model as the alternative path for states reluctant to pursue structural transformation, particularly as China expands its South-South cooperation and India consolidates its G20 leadership. Critically, the women of India and China, roughly one in six of all women worldwide, are consistently present in official discourse as beneficiaries and contributors, but absent as political agents with the standing and rights to speak and fight for themselves. When this pattern scales to global norm-making, what circulates

as international consensus on gender equality risks reflecting state priorities rather than women's claims.

6. Conclusion and Discussion

6.1 Main Findings

This thesis examined how China and India discursively localize global gender norms in domestic official discourse between 2015 and 2025, asking how two major rising powers construct the political meaning of gender equality and engage with its specific international normative commitments for domestic audiences.

Three main findings emerge from the analysis. First, developmental and instrumental framing dominates in both cases, though expressed through different political logics. India's framing is relatively more pluralistic and grounded in constitutional discourse, while China's is more closely tied to Party authority and socialist ideology. In both cases, gender equality is framed mainly as a means to national development rather than as an end in itself.

Second, both corpora display a similar pattern of selective omission. Issues such as reproductive autonomy, SOGI-related rights, feminist civil society, and structural critiques of patriarchy are systematically sidelined or left largely unaddressed in both cases. Their absence across two otherwise different political systems suggests that these dimensions of gender norms remain among the most politically resistant to advancement globally.

Third, both states claim normative authority and actively frame themselves as contributors to global gender governance and women's development. As both grow in geopolitical weight and multilateral influence, this development-oriented, selectively adapted, and statist approach to gender equality risks gradually narrowing the space

for more transformative and autonomous rights-based interpretations in international governance.

These findings should not, however, obscure the dimensions of international gender norms that both cases do meaningfully affirm and embed in domestic gender narratives. Women's economic empowerment, access to education and healthcare, elimination of harmful practices, and protection from gender-based violence all feature prominently in both cases, aligning substantively with CEDAW, the Beijing Platform for Action, and SDG 5.^[40] India's "women-led development" framing pushes international gender norms in the direction of female agency and leadership. China's framing of gender equality as a shared global responsibility, articulated through pledges of South-South cooperation and multilateral engagement, contributes to keeping gender norms embedded in cooperative development agenda at the international level.

6.2 Contributions and Reflections

Contributions The thesis contributes to three areas of scholarship. First, it shifts analytical attention from institutional compliance to domestic political framing, examining how states construct and delimit the meaning of international gender commitments for domestic audiences. Second, methodologically, it extends Entman's (1993) political framing approach by combining it with Bacchi's WPR method, treating silences and omissions as analytically significant as what is explicitly said. Third, by examining China and India as rising powers, it extends existing debates on gender norms beyond the European and North American contexts that dominate much of the literature.

^[40] These include in particular CEDAW Articles 10–14 on education, employment, healthcare, and rural women; Beijing Platform for Action critical areas C (women and health), F (women and the economy), and D (violence against women); and SDG 5 targets 5.1, 5.2, and 5.4 on ending discrimination, eliminating violence, and recognizing unpaid care work.

The main contribution is empirical, however, and this reflects the thesis's core research focus. It provides the first systematic framing analysis of official domestic gender discourse in China and India across a decade, offering insights that help illuminate what the future may hold for international gender norms as the liberal international order gives way to a more multipolar one in which China and India occupy an increasingly consequential place.

Limitations Several limitations are worth acknowledging. First, the corpus is necessarily selective. With 17 texts per country drawn from high-level executive statements, national plans, and official state media, the analysis captures authoritative and politically important articulations of official gender discourse, but cannot claim to be exhaustive. Future research could draw on a larger and more varied sample, extending beyond central governmental communication to include parliamentary debates, line ministry documents, or subnational governance texts.

Second, the interpretive nature of framing analysis means that coding decisions inevitably involve some degree of judgment, especially where multiple frames overlap or where framing remains implicit rather than explicit. The typology developed in Chapter 3 provides a systematic framework for the analysis, but it does not remove interpretive discretion entirely.

Third, as Bacchi and Goodwin (2016) note, the analyst is never fully outside the discourse she examines. My own background, gender position, and familiarity with both contexts inevitably shape what I find salient, as well as what I may overlook or take for granted.

Open Questions for Gender Equality, Rights, and Political Agency

The empirical analysis also raises a broader question that this thesis cannot fully answer, but that the findings make difficult to ignore. Across both cases, women's

economic participation is one of the most developed and emphasized dimensions of official gender discourse. Access to credit, skills, employment, and entrepreneurship is consistently promoted, institutionally supported, and publicly celebrated. Far less developed, however, is the question of women's political agency: the ability to organize independently, define the meaning of women's rights and gender equality on their own terms, and negotiate the frameworks within which empowerment is being offered. In both China and India, women appear mainly as beneficiaries of state support and contributors to national development, rather than as autonomous political actors able to shape the conditions or norms of their own advancement.

This gap matters beyond the two cases studied here. Feminist and gender rights scholarship has long argued that gender equality requires more than economic empowerment: it demands reproductive autonomy (Corrêa et al., 2008), recognition of SOGI-based rights (Baisley, 2016), and the freedom to organize independently and advance feminist politics (Alvarez, 1999; Eschle, 2001). What the analysis reveals is not simply that these dimensions are absent, but that their absence appears structural and politically regulated. Whether developmental framing can, over time, lay the groundwork for more expansive rights claims, or whether state actors use it to foreclose them by absorbing gender equality into state-centric and market-oriented logics, is a question this thesis raises but cannot resolve. It is, however, a question that will matter increasingly as China and India grow in their capacity to shape what gender equality is understood to require

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Appendix: materials and coding

Table A1. India Corpus: Overview of Official Texts (2015–2025)

Note: Type I = High-level executive and state authority texts. Type II = Official communication and state-affiliated media texts.
Corpus total: 17 texts (7 Type I, 10 Type II).

No.	Year	Category	Issuing Actor	Title
1	2015	Type I	Prime Minister of India	Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao: Caring for the Girl Child (protect the girl child, educate the girl child)
2	2015	Type I	Prime Minister of India	English Rendering of the Special Episode of Mann Ki Baat: PM Narendra Modi and US President Barack Obama Share Their Thoughts on Radio (daughters, gender balance and social change)
3	2018	Type I	Vice President's Secretariat	Women Empowerment Is Not Only a National Goal but Also a Global Agenda: Vice President
4	2021	Type II	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Policy To Promote Women Empowerment
5	2022	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP) Scheme (protect the girl child, educate the girl child)
6	2022	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Development of Transgenders (welfare, inclusion and state support measures)
7	2022	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Ministry of Women and Child Development Issues Detailed Guidelines for Mission Shakti Aimed at Strengthening Interventions for Women Safety, Security and Empowerment

8	2022	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Year End Review 2022: Ministry of Women and Child Development
9	2023	Type I	Prime Minister's Office	PM Addresses G20 Ministerial Conference on Women Empowerment
10	2023	Type I	President of India	President of India Graces the Foundation Day Celebration of the National Commission for Women: Women Empowerment Is Not Just an Issue of Social Justice but Also Crucial for Economic Development
11	2024	Type I	Prime Minister of India	PM's Address in Lok Sabha at the Special Discussion on the 75th Anniversary of the Adoption of the Constitution (equality, women's representation, transgender rights and constitutional inclusion)
12	2024	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	NARI SHAKTI: From Women Development to Women-led Development
13	2024	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Government Has Adopted a Multi-pronged Approach for Educational, Social, Economic and Political Empowerment of Women
14	2024	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Welfare of Transgenders
15	2025	Type I	Prime Minister of India	PM's Reply to the Motion of Thanks on the President's Address in Rajya Sabha (equality, women-led development, national progress and inclusion)
16	2025	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Measures for Care of LGBTQ Community
17	2025	Type III	Press Information Bureau (PIB)	Empowered Women Empower the World: International Women's Day 2025

Table A2. China Corpus: Overview of Official Texts (2015–2025)

Note: Type I = High-level executive and party-state authority texts. Type II = Official communication and state-affiliated media texts. Corpus total: 17 texts (10 Type I, 7 Type II).

No.	Year	Category	Issuing Actor	Title
1	2015	Type I	State Council Information Office	China's Gender Equality and Women's Development
2	2015	Type I	Xi Jinping / Xinhua	Full Text of Xi Jinping's Speech at the Global Women's Summit
3	2015	Type II	State Council Information Office	Press Conference on China's Gender Equality and Women's Development
4	2017	Type II	People's Daily	Commemorating the 25th Anniversary of the Law on the Protection of Women's Rights and Interests: Using Law to Safeguard "Her Rights"

5	2018	Type I	Zhao Leji / Party Central Leadership	Address on Behalf of the CPC Central Committee at the Opening of the 12th National Women's Congress
6	2018	Type II	Xinhua / China Government Network	Xi Jinping Meets the New Leadership of the All-China Women's Federation and Delivers an Important Speech
7	2019	Type I	State Council Information Office	Equality, Development and Sharing: Progress of Women's Cause in China over the Past 70 Years (White Paper)
8	2020	Type I	Xi Jinping / Xinhua	Speech at the High-level Meeting on the 25th Anniversary of the Fourth World Conference on Women
9	2021	Type I	State Council	China Women's Development Program (2021–2030)
10	2022	Type II	Xinhua	Investigation into the “Xuzhou Woman with Eight Children” Case (trafficking, women's protection and official accountability, and a key moment of domestic gender controversy)
11	2022	Type II	Xinhua	Focus on the Revised Law on the Protection of Women's Rights and Interests
12	2023	Type I	Ding Xuexiang / Party Central Leadership	Address on Behalf of the CPC Central Committee at the Opening of the 13th National Women's Congress (party-led mobilisation)
13	2023	Type II	Xinhua / China Government Network	Xi Jinping Meets the New Leadership of the All-China Women's Federation and Stresses Following the Socialist Path of Women's Development with Chinese Characteristics
14	2025	Type I	National Bureau of Statistics	Statistical Monitoring Report on the 2023 Implementation of the China Women's Development Program (2021–2030)
15	2025	Type I	State Council Information Office	Practices and Achievements of Promoting Women's All-round Development in the New Era (White Paper)
16	2025	Type I	Xi Jinping / Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Full Text of Xi Jinping's Keynote Speech at the Opening Ceremony of the Global Women's Summit
17	2025	Type II	People's Daily	Empowering Women in the Digital Era: China's New Human Rights Practice in Protecting Women's Rights and Interests

Table A3. India Corpus: Frame Coding Summary (2015–2025)

Note: Dominant frame = the frame that most coherently organizes the problem, cause, value, and policy logic of a text. Auxiliary frames = secondary framing logics present in the text.

No.	Text	Dominant Frame	Auxiliary Frame(s)
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1	Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao: Caring for the Girl Child (2015)	Security & Protection	Developmental; Justice & Rights
2	Mann Ki Baat: PM Modi and President Obama (2015)	Security & Protection	National Identity; Justice & Rights
3	Women Empowerment Is Not Only a National Goal but Also a Global Agenda (2018)	Developmental & Instrumental	Justice & Rights; International Status
4	Policy to Promote Women Empowerment (2021)	Developmental & Instrumental	Security & Protection; Justice & Rights
5	BBBP Scheme FAQ (2022)	Security & Protection	Justice & Rights; Developmental
6	Mission Shakti Guidelines - PIB (2022)	Security & Protection	Developmental; Justice & Rights
7	Development of Transgenders (2022)	Justice & Rights	Security & Protection; Developmental
8	Year End Review: MWC (2022)	Developmental & Instrumental	Security & Protection; Justice & Rights
9	PM Addresses G20 Ministerial Conference on Women Empowerment (2023)	Developmental & Instrumental	National Identity; International Status
10	President Graces Foundation Day of the NCW (2023)	Developmental & Instrumental	Justice & Rights; Security & Protection
11	NARI SHAKTI: From Women Development to Women-Led Development (2024)	Developmental & Instrumental	National Identity; International Status
12	Multi-pronged Approach for Empowerment of Women (2024)	Developmental & Instrumental	Security & Protection
13	PM's Address in Lok Sabha: 75th Anniversary of the Constitution (2024)	Justice & Rights	Developmental; National Identity; International Status
14	Welfare of Transgenders (2024)	Justice & Rights	Security & Protection; Developmental
15	PM's Reply to Motion of Thanks – Rajya Sabha (2025)	Developmental & Instrumental	National Identity; Justice & Rights
16	International Women's Day 2025 (2025)	Developmental & Instrumental	Justice & Rights; International Status
17	Measures for Care of LGBTQ Community (2025)	Justice & Rights	Security & Protection; Developmental

Table A4. China Corpus: Frame Coding Summary (2015–2025)

Note: Dominant frame = the frame that most coherently organizes the problem, cause, value, and policy logic of a text. Auxiliary frames = secondary framing logics present in the text.

No.	Text	Dominant Frame	Auxiliary Frame(s)
1	China's Gender Equality and Women's Development - White Paper(2015)	Developmental & Instrumental	Justice & Rights; International Status
2	Press Conference on China's Gender Equality (2015)	Developmental & Instrumental	Justice & Rights; International Status
3	Xi Jinping's Speech at the Global Women's Summit (2015)	International Status & Contribution	Developmental; Justice & Rights; Security & Protection
4	Using Law to Safeguard 'Her Rights' (2017)	Justice & Rights	Security & Protection; Developmental
5	Address at the 12th National Women's Congress - Zhao (2018)	Party-led National Rejuvenation	Developmental
6	Xi Jinping Meets the New ACWF Leadership (2018)	Party-led National Rejuvenation	Developmental; Justice & Rights
7	Equality, Development and Sharing - 70 Years White Paper (2019)	Developmental & Instrumental	International Status; Justice & Rights
8	Speech at the High-level Meeting on Beijing+25 (2020)	Developmental & Instrumental	International Status; Justice & Rights; Security & Protection
9	China Women's Development Program 2021-2030 (2021)	Developmental & Instrumental	Justice & Rights; Security & Protection
10	Investigation into the Xuzhou Case (2022)	Justice & Rights	Security & Protection
11	Focus on the Revised Law on Women's Rights (2022)	Justice & Rights	Security & Protection
12	Address at the 13th National Women's Congress - Ding (2023)	Party-led National Rejuvenation	Developmental
13	Xi Jinping Stresses Following the Socialist Path (2023)	Party-led National Rejuvenation	Developmental; Justice & Rights
14	Statistical Monitoring Report on CWDP 2021-2030 (2025)	Developmental & Instrumental	Justice & Rights; Security & Protection
15	Practices and Achievements of Promoting Women's All-round Development White Paper (2025)	Developmental & Instrumental	International Status; Justice & Rights
16	Empowering Women in the Digital Era (2025)	Developmental & Instrumental	International Status; Justice & Rights
17	Xi Jinping's Keynote Speech at the Global Women's Summit (2025)	International Status & Contribution	Developmental; Security & Protection; Justice & Rights